Bernice Buttman, Model Citizen

By Niki Lenz

BERNICE: **(Chapter 1)** Here are things that I, Bernice Buttman, was awesome at. One: burping the alphabet. Two: blowing up stuff with firecrackers. Three: wearing the teachers and puny kids of Oak Grove Elementary into nubs. I was less great at knowing what to do with myself at recess.

I sat on top of the monkey bars, feeling like a booger on a cheese ball . . . out of place and unwelcome. Kids whirled all around me, talking to their buddies and playing games, but nobody came within arm's length of me.

INTRODUCTION

When you're a Buttman, the label "bully" comes with the territory, and Bernice lives up to her name. But life as a bully is lonely and if there's one thing Bernice really wants, it's a friend. After her mom skedaddles and leaves her in a new town with her aunt (a real live nun!), Bernice tries to mend her ways and start over. But it's hard to be kind when no one shows you kindness, so a ***few*** *pranks may still be up her sleeve as she works on becoming . . .*

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BERNICE: There was only one kid who I didn't want to clobber: *(dreamily)* Oliver Stratts. He was real smart and smelled like laundry detergent. I wanted him to be my friend. It was time to put my plan in action -- my feet marched me over to the group of snotnosed fifth graders. The kids went quiet. I grabbed one of Oliver's skinny arms and twisted it behind his back. *(he squeals) (in a sweet voice)* Come with me. I've got a present for you.

(to audience) I found the pile of dog doo I'd spotted earlier, and I pushed Oliver's face right up next to it. *(to Oliver)* How would you feel about me and you being friends, Oliver?

OLIVER: *(squirming to get away and avoid the poo)* No way!

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BERNICE: He tried to squirm out from under me, but I outweighed him by about a million pounds. All I had to do was lean forward a smidge, and his nose would touch poo.

OLIVER: *(squeaking through gritted teeth)* Oh, gosh! Oh, man. Let me up, Bernice!

BERNICE: I'll be glad to. When you say you'll be my friend.

OLIVER: *(whining)* Okay, okay, fine.

BERNICE: *(to audience)* I stood slowly and gave Oliver's backside one tiny kick, sending him sprawling only one beardsecond away from the pile of dookie. (A beard-second is the average length a beard grows in one second. Google it.)

OLVIER: *(running away)* You need Jesus, Buttman! You're the meanest girl I know!

BERNICE: Too bad for you, 'cause I'm your new best friend!

MOMMA: *(at the schoolyard fence)* Bernice! Bernice Buttman, get your raggedy behind over here right this minute!

BERNICE: *(reluctantly going to the fence)* What are you doing here? *(to audience)* Momma was wearing pajama pants and slippers, even though it was eleven o'clock.

MOMMA: Imma need my money back.

BERNICE: *(scowling)* What money?

MOMMA: The money I gave you this morning for your lunch.

BERNICE: But I need that money to eat! *(to audience)* All the kids were staring and pointing and laughing.

GINA: Did you see how many chins that woman had? I'll betcha Bernice will look just like her when she's grown.

OLIVER: I heard they steal toilet paper from the gas station bathroom.

BERNICE: ***Not him!*** The rest of the kids could talk, but not my best friend!

MOMMA: *(throwing her hands in the air, frustrated)* Figure something out. Now cough up the cash. I gotta put gas in the car and get to my tattoo appointment.

BERNICE: **(Chapter 7)** I drifted through the following days like a Twinkie wrapper blowing through a parking lot. I tried to avoid Momma as much as possible, [but] she caught me Saturday morning.

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MOMMA: I need to talk to you, Bernice.

BERNICE: I was only 11 years old, but when someone tells you they need to talk, it's never about how they wanna shower you with candy.

MOMMA: I've decided I need to make a move. For my career.

BERNICE: *(puzzled she thinks aloud)* Career?

MOMMA: There's these open auditions in Los Angeles. This could be my big break!

BERNICE: *(excited)* We're movin'! To California? Hotdang! Swimming pools, movie stars!

MOMMA: No, Bernice. Your brothers will stay here. They can take care of themselves. But you require some supervision. *(crosses her arms in a no-nonsense way)* You're gonna go live at Aunt Josephine's.

BERNICE: *(to audience)* My face must have gone as white as a sun-bleached dishrag. *(to Momma)* Wait. . . isn't she a ***nun***?

******* Scene – At the Library*******

BERNICE: *(to audience)* She tried to tell me it would be temporary. As soon as her and Lloyd got jobs on a TV show, they'd come back for me. I laid my face down on the table and squeezed my eyes shut. One traitor tear managed to squeeze out.

MS. KNIGHTLEY: Bernice? What on earth is the matter?

BERNICE: Ms. Knightley, *our librarian*, was the closest thing I had to a friend. She always seemed happy to see me, and she didn't think of me as "one of those awful Buttmans." *(to Ms. Knightley, wailing)* My momma is giving me away. To live with my aunt in a dumb small town. And she's a nun! *(beat)* She can't make me! I'll figure out a way to stay!

MS. KNIGHTLEY: But what if you didn't stay here. What if you ***did*** go live in a new town with new people? *(pause)* Bernice, I know you may not believe what I'm about to say, but this ***might*** be the best thing that's ever happened to you. *(smiling softly)* Going to live in a new place is starting over. It's like a clean slate. Sometimes it's the people around us who help us figure out who we are.

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BERNICE: *(crossing arms dejectedly)* I already knew who I was. Bernice Buttman. Cheese ball eater. Kindergarten money stealer. School terrorizer. Mini-version of my momma. *(sadly)* But was that who I had to be? Who I wanted to be? What if Ms. Knightley was right -- A new beginning. A new adventure.

******* Scene – At her new school – Halfway Primary School*******

BERNICE: **(Chapter 10)** I'm so nervous I don't know whether to scratch my watch or wind my butt. **(Chapter 9)** I kept telling myself things could be different in Halfway. No one knew me, or my family. I'd never threatened to push anyone's nose in dog doo here or stolen any milk money. *(pause, knocks on the classroom door and steps inside)* The first person I saw when I walked into Mr. Newton's 5th-grade class was Mr. Newton himself.

MR. NEWTON: Bernice Buttman?

BERNICE: *(to audience as an aside)* Shoot. Permanent file. So much for forging a new identity.

IMOGENE: *(eagerly raising her hand)* Mr. Newton? Excuse me, Mr. Newton? Would you like me to show Bernice Buttman around?

BERNICE: *(rolling her eyes)* I managed to stay mostly invisible for the first part of the day. [But] before I knew it, the lunch bell rang.

IMOGENE: *(with too much enthusiasm)* I can't wait to show you all around, Bernice. I promise to do whatever it takes to make you feel welcome here. *(with fake surprise and batting her eyelashes)* Oh, Principal Jenkins, I didn't see you there.

FRANCIE: **(Chapter 13)** *(whispering to Bernice)* She'd bring muffin baskets to his house once a week if she thought it would help her get the Principal's Citizenship Award.

BERNICE: What's the Principal's Citizenship Award?

FRANCIE: It's this award they give out to one fifth-grade kid each year. If you win you get a thousand dollars and a trip to Jefferson City to meet the governor.

BERNICE: Bernice Buttman was not the kind of girl who won citizenship awards. I was the kind of girl who kicked those prizewinners in the shins. [But then] A lightbulb turned

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on in my brain. I knew exactly what to do. *(to Principal Jenkins, matching Imogene's fakeness)* Mr. Jenkins? *(offering her hand to shake)* I live at St. Drogo's with the nuns . . .

PRINCIPAL JENKINS: Yes. Sister Marie Francis says you've been quite the blessing to them. And how wonderful that you've taken an interest in helping the poor.

BERNICE: I consider myself a global ***citizen,*** sir. Always looking out for others. *(Jenkins moves on)*

IMOGENE: *(indignant, and not so nice now)* If you're talking about getting the Principal's Citizenship Award, you can forget it. I've been volunteering after school to prove to everyone how good a citizen I am. Living with nuns doesn't make you good.

BERNICE: *(sweetly)* I don't care if I win any dumb awards. But it sure would make me happy if ***you*** didn't. *(Imogene stomps off) (to audience)* Maybe I could treat this whole "being nice" thing like it was a part I'd been assigned. Like acting. Yeah. ***Be nice.*** It was harder than it sounded.

(Chapter 19) It was the Monday after Thanksgiving break when the idea hit me. *(rubbing her hands together and cackling)* I sat at my computer and typed a professionally worded letter of congratulations, sealed it in a long white envelope. I got to class early and placed the letter on Imogene's desk before anyone else arrived.

IMOGENE: *(notices the envelope, opens it and smiles as she reads, her hand shoots into the air)* I have an announcement! It's really exciting! *(walks to the front of the room, beaming)*

BERNICE: *(to audience)* She had rays of sunbeams shining out her nostrils, I tell you what.

IMOGENE: Everyone, I just received confirmation that I've been chosen for the Principal's Citizenship Award. *(squeals)* It says . . . and I quote: *"Imogene Franklin is the most model student at Halfway Primary. She expresses her love of the community by constantly sucking up to teachers and having her father write bit checks to charity." (her smile sags)*

STUDENT: Sounds about right! *(laughing)*

IMOGENE: *(continues reading with some confusion) "The recipient of this special award will get to run extra laps in PE for the rest of the school year."* That doesn't seem right.

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MR. NEWTON: Take this letter to the principal immediately so [he] can verify its validity

STUDENTS: *(giggling)*

BERNICE: *(gleefully)* You could see the wheels turning in Imogene's brain as she walked to the classroom door. She paused with her hand on the knob and turned slowly, glaring at me. She was mad enough to eat barbed wire and poop nails. I should've been happy . . . I mean, Imogene had thought so much of herself . . . And she had announced it to the whole class and everyone had laughed at her. ***Added bonus.*** But it didn't matter if you were squashing people or writing them fake awards, eventually you got caught and you had to pay the price for bullying. **(Chapter 23)** I should've known Momma would show up *(beat)* . . . at church!

********Scene********

MOMMA: Bernice! Honey, let's get out of here. I'm gonna take you out for some fried chicken.

BERNICE: *(horrified)* What're you doin'?

MOMMA: Look at you, living like a woman of the cloth. Do they got you praying ten times a day and shining up their crucifixes?

BERNICE: *(embarrassed, she speaks to the congregation)* Everything's a joke to her.

MOMMA: I've come to fetch you. California didn't work out for me.

BERNICE: **(Chapter 18)** What would Ms. Knightley tell me to do?

MS. KNIGHTLEY: **(Chapter 7)** *(echos)* Going to live in a new place is starting over. It's like a clean slate. Sometimes it's the people around us who help us figure out who we are.

BERNICE: *(with conviction)* [I am not a] Kindergarten money stealer. School terrorizer. Mini-version of my momma. **(Chapter 25)** When you are raised to only think about yourself and getting what you want, you don't turn out to be a very nice person. *(beat)* **(Chapter 26)** There were a lot of good things about living in Halfway.

********Scene – a few week after Momma leaves*******

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BERNICE: **(Chapter 28)** The town square was busy, even for a Saturday afternoon, and when I rounded the corner I saw a herd of small kids running around the courthouse lawn. Only one voice attempted to calm the chaos.

IMOGENE: Everyone, sit down. Sit down now! We need to start our program.

BERNICE: Did you start your own day care or something?

IMOGENE: This is a day camp I organize. I watch the children so their parents can shop. The Halfway Chamber of Commerce said it was the best service project ever. It shows what a good citizen I am.

BERNICE: I thought you already got that award.

IMOGENE: *(glaring)* Can you leave now, so I can get them to come back to the grass.

BERNICE: *(to audience)* My eyes narrowed at the scrunched-up set of Imogene's shoulders, and something inside me went mushy. *(to Imogene)* I have a better idea. How 'bout I stay and help you? *(to audience with pride)* I spent the afternoon helping the citizens of Halfway. And I didn't expect anything in return. *(strikes a super-hero pose)* Bernice Buttman – Model Citizen!

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AWARD HISTORY

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